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Conclusions

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And finally, let us focus on the Conclusions chapter. This is where you can show off the results of your modelling efforts, and answer the question(s) you posed yourself. To do so in a coherent way, this chapter should contain:

- The main problem,
- The conclusions you draw from your modelling, based on earlier chapter conclusions,

The focus of this chapter should lie on answering the questions posed in the introduction, in a complete and coherent way. The methods used are less important here, since the reader can find these in the relevant chapters. This distinguishes the Conclusions chapter from the Summary chapter, which has more information on methods and is less detailed in drawing conclusions.

The Conclusions chapter may not contain any new information. It should be based completely on the core chapters of the report.

The Conclusions chapter may also contain a discussion of shortcomings of the model, and recommendations for further research. Another choice is to include those in a separate chapter called Discussion and recommendations.

Exercise A

1/1 point (graded)

What is true about the Conclusions in a report?

☐ The conclusions should always contain a figure or a table.

☒ The conclusions should answer the main question from the introduction. ✓

☐ The conclusions can contain new information.

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- ☐ The conclusions are always the last chapter of a report.

Answer

Correct:

Correct!: A direct relation between the main question from the introduction and the conclusions is essential. Make sure the conclusions start with a repetition of the main question, directly followed by the answer to this question.

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You have used 1 of 3 attempts

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Exercise B

1/1 point (graded)

In this example, the following main question is stated in the introduction:

The purpose of this research is to compare two systems for sewage purification, X and Y, in order to judge which system is most suitable for the sewage purification plant in Andel. Both systems are assessed on purification yield, investment costs and energy consumption.

Two students have written a conclusion chapter.

Student A has written the following conclusion:

The purification yield is 5% higher with Y than with X, especially as a result of the time air bubbles and water are in contact. The investment costs of X are lower ...

Student B has written the following conclusion

X is the most suitable system for the water purification plant in Andel. The investment costs are 30% lower than with Y. However the purification yield of...

Which conclusion do your think is the clearest answer to the main question?

- ☐ Conclusion A, because it starts with the results;

- ☐ Conclusion A because it contains the most details;

- ☒ Conclusion B, because it directly answers the main question; ✓

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Exercise C

1/1 point (graded)

One of the requirements of a conclusion is that it should be readable as a stand-alone document.

Why is this the case?

- ☐ Because readers have bad memory, they have often forgotten the content of the report by the time they reach the conclusions;
- ☐ Because the reader usually takes several days to read the report;
- ☒ Because readers do not read the report from front to back, but often in a different order. ✓

Answer

Correct:

Most readers of the report will look at the conclusions. Some readers such as decision makers often skip the main chapters after the introduction and go straight to the conclusions.

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Exercise D

1/1 point (graded)

Which of the following options help to make the conclusions readable as a stand-alone document?

- ☒ Restating the main question from the introduction; ✓

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☐ Explaining the background of the whole report.

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On the next page, you can post questions you might have about what to write in the introduction, summary or conclusions of a report.

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English ▼

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